VOL. 1 THE INTELLIGENT ROBOT

THE FOULANE FAMILY



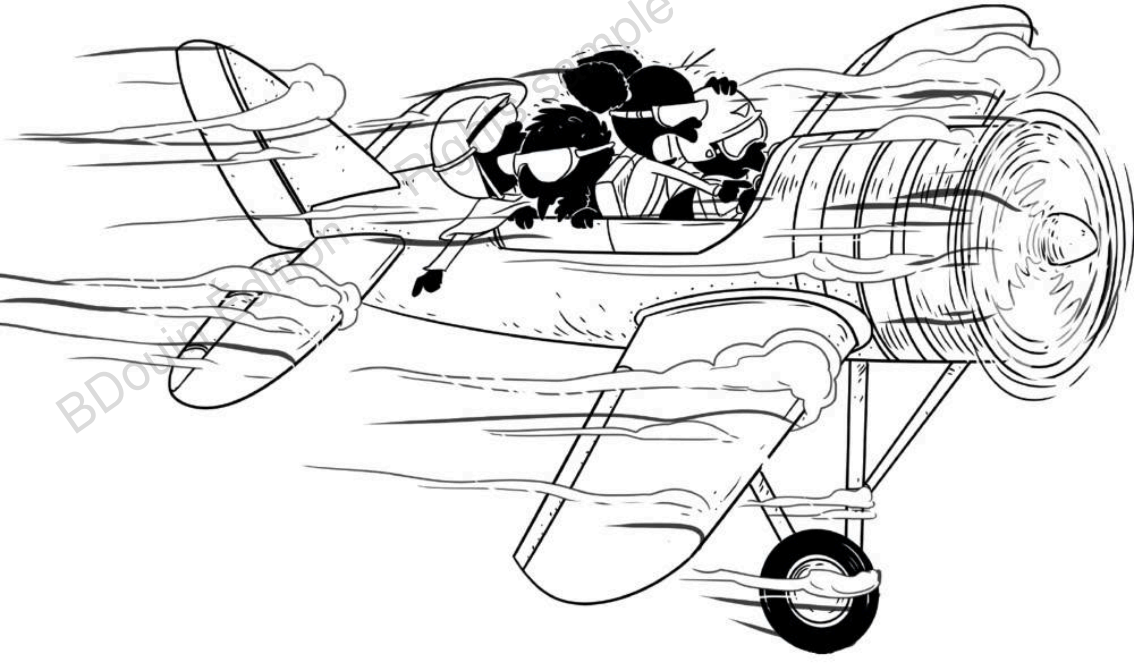
NORÉDINE ALLAM

THE FOULANE FAMILY

1. The Intelligent Robot

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The Foulane Family
Vol.1
The Intelligent Robot
By Norédine Allam.

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Assalaamu ‘alaikum!

My name is Walad, and I’m the youngest in the Foulane family. I’ve got a very special job: to tell you all about our adventures. And believe me, some of them will really surprise you! But before I begin, I should introduce everyone, because it wouldn’t be polite to start without that.

First, there’s Oummi, my mum.

Of course, we always start with the most important person. Oummi works from home as a food blogger. It seems like she’s really famous. But as she never posts any photos of herself, no one recognises her in the street or asks for her autograph.

She spends the whole day making delicious meals and often bakes fancy cakes. And as we shouldn’t waste food, I get to take them as snacks to school the next day.

When she’s not cooking, Oummi spends her time studying from her books. There are books *everywhere* in the living room. She loves her books more than anything. But not more than us though…

Next, there’s my dad, Abi. It’s hard to describe him in just a few words. In just one day, he can be nice or grumpy, tired or bursting with energy, sick or perfectly fine. You never know what he’ll be like the next hour!

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Oummi says he's moony... or is it moody? I don't quite remember.

He works in a maktaba – it's kind of a book shop that sells a little bit of everything: books, carpets, perfumes, clothes... I love it when Abi takes me there. He lets me look through the shelves to search for hidden treasures.

The funny thing is, we always have to test the products before selling them. My speciality is testing the sweets.

And last but not least, there's me! Wa...

Oh no, I almost forgot again. There's also my sister, Binti: my BIG sister.

Sometimes I remind her that she's only one year older than me, and that's not much. But she always says that it's not a year at all, it's actually 370 and a half days!

With Binti, it's all or nothing. One day, we're best friends. The next, we're the worst enemies.

But most of the time, we get along. I make the extra effort, since she talks so loudly! Sometimes she even shouts right in my ear, as if I can't hear properly. But it's okay, I try to be patient.

Oummi says I should practise being patient with girls now, as when I grow up, I'll need even more of it!

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And then, there's me, Walad!

I'm the youngest and the favourite in the family! At least that's what Binti says.

What I love most is playing in my room with my toys. I've got all sorts: planes, puzzles, cars, planes, marbles, planes... Did I mention I love planes?

In sha Allah, when I grow up, I'll be an airline pilot! Then I can take Oummi to Hajj every year and Abi can travel around the world looking for the best miswak.

And Binti? She'll be my co-pilot.

But I should probably make sure I have a good helmet first...

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1. A mysterious amanah

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DIIING DOONG knock knock
DIING DOONG knock knock!



It was 8:45 in the evening when our neighbour came knocking on the door. We knew it was him because he always has this strange way of knocking and ringing the door bell at the same time.

Mr. Stroggof has been our neighbour for as long as I can remember. He's Russian, but my dad says it's strange because he speaks with a bit of a Spanish accent. His job is to invent incredible machines for people all over the world.

Every time he wants to test a new machine, he goes to the garden and shows us. Me and Binti find that very funny.

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Once, he even built a rocket powered by a neujellibean engine. Binti gave it that name because when it took off, the rocket left behind bubbly trails shaped like jelly beans.



That evening, he came to give Abi something important before leaving in a hurry to visit his brother in Russia. He said it was a super-secret invention.

My dad does not like situations like this, because he knows he can never say no to our neighbour.

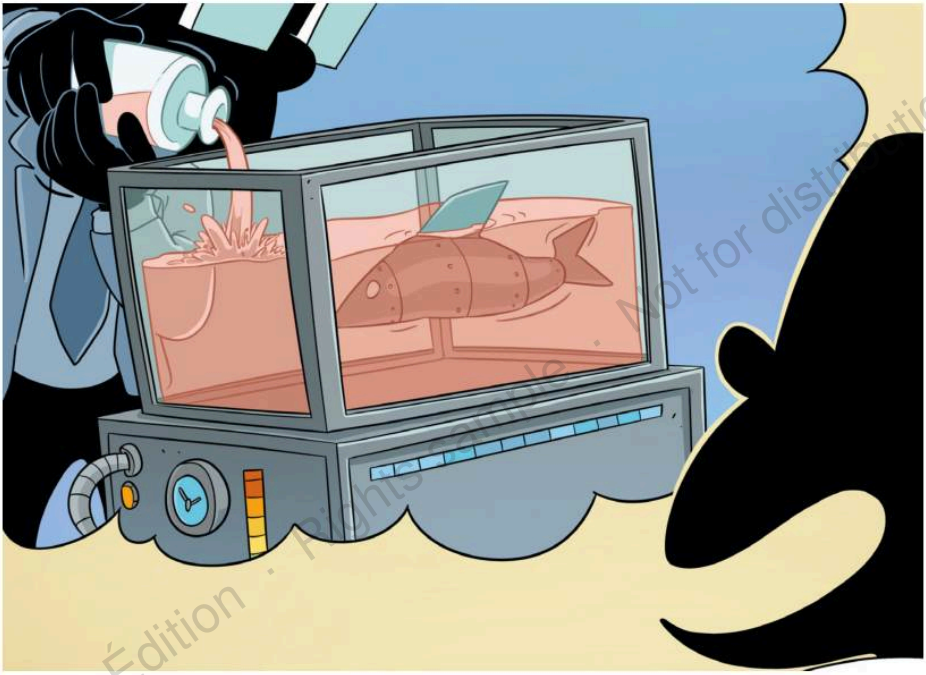
Oummi often reminds us that neighbours have a special place in Islam.

Mr. Stroggof never really enters our house. He just stands in the doorway, talks with Abi, and then leaves just as quickly as he arrived.

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“Can you guess what he came to ask for this time?” asked Binti.

“I don’t know... hmm... maybe some strawberry syrup to turn the water red in the aquarium he’s building for a mechanical shark?” I replied.



“That’s nonsense!” Binti said to me. “I think he came to borrow some toilet roll to write his new maths formula one...”

“Now YOU’RE talking nonsense! Why would he write numbers on toilet roll?” I replied.

“Because his calculation is so long that he needs a piece of paper more than twenty metres long to write without stopping,” Binti explained confidently.

Binti always has weird ideas.

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After a few minutes, Abi returned to the living room carrying a large box in his arms. He put it down on the coffee table, sat on the sofa and began staring at it closely. Oummi joined us and we all sat around.



"What is it?" asked Oummi.

"The neighbour just gave me this," Abi replied. "It's one of his latest inventions. He asked me to keep it safe."

"Now, kids, I'm WARNING you!" Oummi said, pointing her finger at us. "It's an amanah! Do you know what that means?"

"Oh yes, we do!" we answered. "It means it's something entrusted to us, and anyone who damages it will be punished for a whole month." Oummi is very serious about this.

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Oummi says that in Islam, a trust is something very important. And if it comes from a neighbour, then it's even more important...

"What's inside?" asked Binti curiously.

"If I understood correctly, there is a robot inside," explained Abi, still staring at the box.

"A ROBOT?! Wow, that's amazing!" said Binti, starting to get excited.

"Calm down, Binti. Calm down!" warned Oummi. "You're not allowed to touch it. In fact, NO ONE here is allowed! It'll stay safe in its box, in the cupboard."



"It's a bit more complicated than that," Abi added.

"What do you mean?" asked Oummi.

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“Mr. Stroggof asked me for a favour,” explained Abi. “He wants me to take the robot out of its box and let it sit in a corner of the room.”

“Oh no... that’s not very smart,” said Oummi, who had already guessed things were going to get messy with us around. Binti and I couldn’t hold back our excitement! The suspense was just too much.

A robot? But what kind of robot?



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A transformer robot that can turn into a plane? A blender robot for cooking?

A robot dog that needs walking?

What kind of robot could be inside? Judging by the size of the box, it must be enormous!

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Then Abi stood up, put his hands on the cardboard, unfastened a few safety locks, and gently lifted the largest part of the box.



The tension was at its peak, and we could see Oummi's eyes filling with worry.
As for me and Binti, we could barely contain ourselves!



"Come on, Abi! Come on! Open it faster!"
But Abi was taking his time...

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2. What's your name?

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Me and Binti had imagined everything, but not this. We thought opening the box would stop us wondering, but it only made us wonder more.



It was just that this robot had a very strange shape. A bit like an…

"Ostrich egg!" suggested Oummi, who was also very surprised by its appearance.

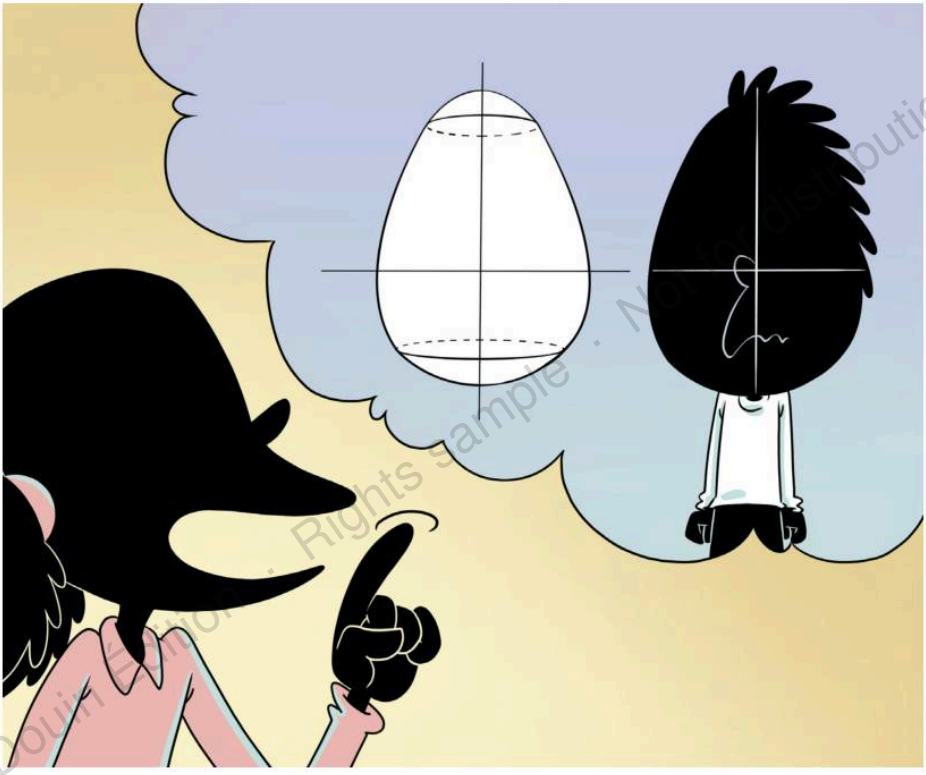
"Not at all," said Binti. "It's an *ovoid* robot!"



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“Ovoid?” Abi was surprised. “Who taught you that word?”

“We learnt the names of shapes at school,” Binti replied proudly. “When something has the shape of an egg, we say it’s ovoid. Like Walad’s head! Ha, ha, ha!”



“Nonsense!” I answered back. “If you keep going, I’ll rearrange your face!”

“Children, calm down now!” Oummi shouted, stopping us straight away before it turned into a fight.

One thing was certain. The robot had a very strange shape, and the oddest part was that there didn’t seem to be any way to turn it on or off.

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